

Green Paper 04 — Attention as Ethics

Green Papers: Notes Toward Planetary Guardianship

Status: Working paper (v0.1). Revised over time. · January 2026

Abstract

This paper proposes attention as a form of ethical infrastructure. What we attend to shapes what becomes real, what becomes actionable, and what becomes morally relevant. Ethics is often framed as principles or duties, but in practice it begins earlier: with perception, selection, and presence.

1. Attention comes before judgment

Before we decide what is right, we decide what is real.

2. The attention economy is an ethical environment

Contemporary life reorganizes attention through speed, novelty, interruption, and competition.

3. Collapse patterns: what happens under overload

Under overload, attention becomes narrow. This narrowing is not a personal weakness; it is a biological and systemic response to stress.

4. Attention as care

Care can be understood as the practice of sustained attention.

5. Civic and institutional attention

Attention is not only individual. Institutions train attention through what they measure, reward, and ignore.

6. Planetary attention

Planetary crises are attention crises, not because people are indifferent, but because the scale and complexity exceed default capacities.

Closing questions

- What do our institutions train us to notice—and to ignore?
- Where does moral attention collapse first: body, relation, or institution?
- What protects attention from chronic interruption and reactivity?
- How do we build long-horizon attention without ideology or burnout?
- What would it mean to design governance as “attention infrastructure”?

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